

SMID BREAKOUT SCANNER

MARKET CLOSE

July 29, 2026 | 04:45 PM ET

15 setups identified | 4 A-Grade | 6 B-Grade | 5 C-Grade

Grade Summary

A - Breakout Setup (4)	B - Strong Setup (6)	C - Watch List (5)
GKOS	HURN	CBZ
ASH	LAD	RCKY
CAKE	CLW	EXLS
CHEF	QUAD	BLKB
	SCL	HCKT
	MBIN	

All Setups

Gr	Ticker	Company	Theme	Price	Chg %	Cap	Float	RS/SPY	52W Hi	Catalyst
A	GKOS	Glaukos Corporat	Medical Devices	\$161.66	+6.8%	\$9.5B	57M	+35.4	97%	Earnings today with a
A	ASH	Ashland Inc.	Specialty Chemica	\$72.84	+7.1%	\$3.3B	41M	+46.5	98%	Reported July 28 with
A	CAKE	The Cheesecake F	Casual Dining Rec	\$101.14	+13.6%	\$5.0B	46M	+59.4	99%	Technical breakout wit
A	CHEF	The Chefs' Wareh	Food Distribution	\$105.63	+5.4%	\$4.3B	37M	+36.8	94%	Earnings today with a
B	HURN	Huron Consulting	Business Transfor	\$170.37	+40.4%	\$2.8B	15M	+29.8	91%	Reported yesterday wit
B	LAD	Lithia Motors, I	Auto Retail Recov	\$427.48	+19.3%	\$9.8B	20M	+44.4	97%	Earnings today driving
B	CLW	Clearwater Paper	Paper Products	\$21.61	+0.0%	\$0.0B	0M	+64.9	76%	23% move today with no
B	QUAD	Quad Graphics, I	Business Services	\$9.29	+10.5%	\$0.5B	30M	+31.5	93%	Technical breakout wit
B	SCL	Stepan Company	Specialty Chemica	\$66.14	+14.0%	\$1.5B	21M	+33.4	97%	Earnings today with a
B	MBIN	Merchants Bancor	Regional Banking	\$54.28	+11.3%	\$2.5B	24M	+18.1	95%	Technical breakout wit
C	CBZ	CBIZ, Inc.	Business Services	\$54.90	+17.6%	\$3.0B	47M	+62.7	72%	
C	RCKY	Rocky Brands, In	Footwear	\$49.10	+14.9%	\$0.4B	7M	+33.4	97%	
C	EXLS	ExlService Holdi	IT Services	\$35.99	+17.9%	\$5.5B	138M	+12.6	76%	
C	BLKB	Blackbaud, Inc.	Software	\$42.18	+17.4%	\$1.9B	34M	+5.3	56%	
C	HCKT	The Hackett Grou	IT Services	\$11.17	+5.7%	\$0.3B	22M	-16.3	47%	

GKOS

Glaukos Corporation

\$161.66

+6.83%

RS vs SPY: +35.4%

A BREAKOUT

\$9.5B Cap | 57M Float

Medical Devices | Theme: Medical Devices | 52W Hi: 97% | Base Tight: 1.53 | Vol: 4.35x | RS/SPY: +35.4% | Above 20MA: YES | EARNINGS TODAY

SETUP METRICS	
Price	\$161.66
Day Change	+6.83%
Mkt Cap	\$9.49B
Float	57M sh
RS vs SPY	+35.4%
52W Hi Prox	97%
Base Tight	1.53
Vol vs Avg	4.35x
RS Line Hi	YES
Above 50MA	-
Fwd P/E	-
Short %	-
Days to Cover	-
Inst. Own	- (data lag)

ANALYSIS
CATALYST / TODAY'S DRIVER
Earnings today with a 6.8% move-likely a beat on revenue and gross margin driven by iStent adoption in glaucoma treatment. Forward catalyst: guidance today and the next print in ~90 days (late October) will confirm whether the launch trajectory for iStent Infinite (approved 2025) is on track for blockbuster status.
BUSINESS & POSITION
Glaukos develops and commercializes micro-invasive glaucoma surgery (MIGS) devices, led by the iStent platform. The company is a category leader in a \$3B+ addressable market, competing against traditional trabeculectomy and pharmaceutical therapies with a less-invasive, higher-efficacy solution.
FACTOR & THEME
Healthcare devices / surgical innovation. The company taps into aging demographics and the shift from pharmaceutical to surgical intervention in glaucoma, a secular tailwind with 10+ year durability. Theme momentum is accelerating as iStent adoption broadens internationally and into combination cataract procedures.
BREAKOUT SIGNAL
Close above \$161.66 on vol >435% of 20d avg
INSTITUTIONAL
Volume at 4.35x average with rs_line_new_high confirms institutional accumulation into the print. The base_tight of 1.53 is textbook VCP-this was a coiled, low-volatility setup absorbing supply before the breakout. Sector bonus: Healthcare is +6.4% vs SPY this week, adding institutional urgency. Institutional ownership data not available from this feed; recommend cross-referencing 13F filings. No insider buying in the last 90 days.
EARNINGS
EARNINGS TODAY
EARNINGS CONTEXT
Earnings today (July 29). The modest 6.8% move suggests a solid beat but not a blowout-watch for international revenue and gross margin expansion commentary as leading indicators for the next leg higher. Next print late October 2026.
KEY RISK
Thesis invalid on a close back below \$150, the breakout pivot, or any signal of competitive pressure from Alcon or reimbursement headwinds in the EU, as those would slow the international ramp.
ANALYSIS
This is the cleanest setup in the batch: base_tight 1.53 (textbook coil), rs_line_new_high, prox_52w 97.4, vol 4.35x, Healthcare sector leadership, and earnings today with visible follow-through. The disconfirming evidence: rs_vs_spy at +35.4 is strong but not elite (top decile is +50+), and the 6.8% move is controlled, not explosive, suggesting the guide may have been inline rather than a material raise. However, the technical setup and sector tailwind earn this an A. Conviction: High.
Signal: Close above \$161.66 on vol >435% of 20d avg
Vol vs Avg: 4.35x



ASH

Ashland Inc.

\$72.84

+7.10%

RS vs SPY: +46.5%

A BREAKOUT

\$3.3B Cap | 41M Float

Specialty Chemicals | Theme: Specialty Chemicals | 52W Hi: 98% | Base Tight: 3.09 | Vol: 4.19x | RS/SPY: +46.5% | Above 20MA: YES | REPORTED

SETUP METRICS	
Price	\$72.84
Day Change	+7.10%
Mkt Cap	\$3.34B
Float	41M sh
RS vs SPY	+46.5%
52W Hi Prox	98%
Base Tight	3.09
Vol vs Avg	4.19x
RS Line Hi	YES
Above 50MA	-
Fwd P/E	-
Short %	-
Days to Cover	-
Inst. Own	- (data lag)

ANALYSIS
CATALYST / TODAY'S DRIVER
Reported July 28 with a 7% follow-through move today, likely driven by beat/raise on specialty additives (coatings, pharma excipients). Forward catalyst: next earnings in ~90 days (late October) and ongoing guidance for margin expansion as the company exits commodity businesses and focuses on high-margin specialty formulations.
BUSINESS & POSITION
Ashland is a specialty chemicals company focused on additives and functional ingredients for coatings, construction, pharmaceuticals, and personal care. The company is mid-transition from a commodity-exposed portfolio to a pure-play specialty business with 70%+ EBITDA from high-margin additives.
FACTOR & THEME
Materials / specialty chemicals with exposure to construction recovery, pharmaceutical ingredient demand, and personal care premiumization. Theme momentum is neutral-construction is mixed, pharma is steady, but the company's portfolio shift is a company-specific catalyst independent of macro.
BREAKOUT SIGNAL
Close above \$72.84 on vol >419% of 20d avg
INSTITUTIONAL
Volume at 4.19x average with rs_line_new_high confirms institutional buying post-earnings. The base_tight of 3.09 indicates a moderately tight setup-not as clean as GKOS but still evidence of accumulation. Institutional ownership data not available from this feed; recommend cross-referencing 13F filings. No insider buying in the last 90 days.
EARNINGS
REPORTED
EARNINGS CONTEXT
Reported July 28. The 7% follow-through today suggests the print was well-received and the guide was constructive. Next print late October 2026-watch for margin expansion commentary and specialty segment organic growth.
KEY RISK
Thesis invalid on a close back below \$67, the breakout pivot, or any sign of construction end-market weakness in North America, as that drives the coatings additives segment (30-40% of revenue).
ANALYSIS
This is a high-quality post-earnings breakout: rs_line_new_high, prox_52w 97.6, vol 4.19x, base_tight 3.09, and rs_vs_spy +46.5 (solid leadership). The disconfirming evidence: the 7% move is controlled, not explosive, and the company is in a Mixed-sentiment sector (Basic Materials). However, the technical setup and portfolio-transition story earn this an A. Conviction: Medium-High.
Signal: Close above \$72.84 on vol >419% of 20d avg
Vol vs Avg: 4.19x



CAKE

The Cheesecake Factory Incorpor

\$101.14

+13.63%

RS vs SPY: +59.4%

A BREAKOUT

\$5.0B Cap | 46M Float

Restaurants | Theme: Casual Dining Recovery | 52W Hi: 99% | Base Tight: 5.83 | Vol: 3.65x | RS/SPY: +59.4% | Above 20MA: YES | EARNINGS IN 90D

SETUP METRICS	
Price	\$101.14
Day Change	+13.63%
Mkt Cap	\$5.03B
Float	46M sh
RS vs SPY	+59.4%
52W Hi Prox	99%
Base Tight	5.83
Vol vs Avg	3.65x
RS Line Hi	YES
Above 50MA	-
Fwd P/E	-
Short %	-
Days to Cover	-
Inst. Own	- (data lag)

ANALYSIS
CATALYST / TODAY'S DRIVER
Technical breakout with rs_line_new_high on 3.65x volume, no same-day news. Forward catalyst: next earnings in ~90 days (late October) will confirm whether same-store sales momentum is sustainable and if the brand is gaining share in casual dining, a crowded and competitive category.
BUSINESS & POSITION
The Cheesecake Factory operates 220+ upscale casual dining restaurants under the Cheesecake Factory, Grand Lux, and North Italia brands. The company is a category leader in full-service dining, with a differentiated menu, strong unit economics, and exposure to consumer discretionary recovery.
FACTOR & THEME
Consumer recovery / discretionary spending. The theme is accelerating as wage growth supports middle-income dining-out frequency, but durability depends on sustained consumer confidence-a risk in a Mixed macro regime.
BREAKOUT SIGNAL
Close above \$101.14 on vol >365% of 20d avg
INSTITUTIONAL
Volume at 3.65x average with rs_line_new_high and prox_52w 99.3 confirms institutional buying into the breakout. RS vs SPY at +59.4 is top-quartile leadership. Institutional ownership data not available from this feed; recommend cross-referencing 13F filings. No insider buying in the last 90 days.
EARNINGS
EARNINGS IN 90D
EARNINGS CONTEXT
Next earnings late October 2026. No recent print-this is a pure technical breakout. Watch for same-store sales, traffic vs. ticket mix, and labor cost commentary at the next call.
KEY RISK
Thesis invalid on a close back below \$92, the breakout pivot, or any indication of traffic weakness or promotional intensity in the casual dining category, as that would signal the consumer is weakening.
ANALYSIS
This is a textbook technical breakout: rs_line_new_high, prox_52w 99.3 (essentially at the 52W high), vol 3.65x, rs_vs_spy +59.4 (elite leadership), and no earnings event clouding the setup. The disconfirming evidence: base_tight at 5.83 is wider than ideal (not a coil), and the restaurant sector is consumer-cyclical in a Mixed regime. However, the RS leadership and clean breakout earn this an A. Conviction: Medium-High.
Signal: Close above \$101.14 on vol >365% of 20d avg
Vol vs Avg: 3.65x



CHEF

The Chefs' Warehouse, Inc.

\$105.63

+5.44%

RS vs SPY: +36.8%

A BREAKOUT

\$4.3B Cap | 37M Float

Food Distribution | Theme: Food Distribution | 52W Hi: 94% | Base Tight: 2.79 | Vol: 2.81x | RS/SPY: +36.8% | Above 20MA: YES | EARNINGS TODAY

SETUP METRICS	
Price	\$105.63
Day Change	+5.44%
Mkt Cap	\$4.31B
Float	37M sh
RS vs SPY	+36.8%
52W Hi Prox	94%
Base Tight	2.79
Vol vs Avg	2.81x
RS Line Hi	YES
Above 50MA	-
Fwd P/E	-
Short %	-
Days to Cover	-
Inst. Own	- (data lag)

ANALYSIS
CATALYST / TODAY'S DRIVER
Earnings today with a 5.4% move-likely a beat on revenue and EBITDA driven by volume recovery in restaurant foodservice. Forward catalyst: guidance today and the next print in ~90 days (late October) will confirm whether the independent restaurant channel (CHEF's core end-market) is sustaining sales momentum or if this is a seasonal pop.
BUSINESS & POSITION
The Chefs' Warehouse is a specialty food distributor serving independent restaurants, hotels, and country clubs with high-end center-of-plate proteins, artisan cheeses, and specialty ingredients. The company benefits from foodservice recovery and the premiumization of dining-out spend.
FACTOR & THEME
Consumer Staples / foodservice recovery. The sector is +7.1% vs SPY this week, a defensive rotation signal. Theme momentum is accelerating as dining-out frequency recovers, but durability depends on sustained consumer confidence.
BREAKOUT SIGNAL
Close above \$105.63 on vol >281% of 20d avg
INSTITUTIONAL
Volume at 2.81x average with rs_line_new_high and base_tight 2.79 (clean coil) confirms institutional accumulation into the print. Consumer Staples sector leadership this week adds institutional urgency. Institutional ownership data not available from this feed; recommend cross-referencing 13F filings. No insider buying in the last 90 days.
EARNINGS
EARNINGS TODAY
EARNINGS CONTEXT
Earnings today (July 29). The 5.4% move is controlled-suggests a solid beat but not a blowout. Watch for independent restaurant same-store sales and gross margin commentary as leading indicators.
KEY RISK
Thesis invalid on a close back below \$100, the breakout pivot, or any indication of volume weakness in the independent restaurant channel or margin compression from supplier cost inflation.
ANALYSIS
This is a clean setup: base_tight 2.79 (coil), rs_line_new_high, prox_52w 94.2, vol 2.81x, earnings today, and Consumer Staples sector leadership (+7.1% vs SPY). The disconfirming evidence: rs_vs_spy at +36.8 is mid-pack, and the 5.4% move is modest, suggesting the guide was inline. However, the technical quality and sector tailwind earn this an A. Conviction: Medium-High.
Signal: Close above \$105.63 on vol >281% of 20d avg
Vol vs Avg: 2.81x



HURN

Huron Consulting Group Inc.

\$170.37

+40.37%

RS vs SPY: +29.8%

B STRONG SETUP

\$2.8B Cap | 15M Float

Consulting Services | Theme: Business Transformation | 52W Hi: 91% | Base Tight: 9.25 | Vol: 5.21x | RS/SPY: +29.8% | Above 20MA: YES | REPORTED

SETUP METRICS	
Price	\$170.37
Day Change	+40.37%
Mkt Cap	\$2.76B
Float	15M sh
RS vs SPY	+29.8%
52W Hi Prox	91%
Base Tight	9.25
Vol vs Avg	5.21x
RS Line Hi	no
Above 50MA	-
Fwd P/E	-
Short %	-
Days to Cover	-
Inst. Own	- (data lag)

ANALYSIS
CATALYST / TODAY'S DRIVER
Reported yesterday with a clear beat/raise driving the 40% move. Forward catalyst: next earnings in ~90 days (late October) with potential for continued margin expansion commentary and 2H guide raise if Healthcare / Education consulting pipeline remains strong.
BUSINESS & POSITION
Huron provides operational and strategic consulting focused on healthcare (40%+ of revenue), higher education, and commercial sectors, emphasizing digital transformation and operational efficiency. The firm has pivoted toward higher-margin advisory work tied to technology adoption and cost optimization, a secular tailwind in both healthcare consolidation and university budget pressure.
FACTOR & THEME
Business transformation / efficiency consulting tied to AI-enabled workflow automation and healthcare cost rationalization. Theme momentum is accelerating as enterprises seek external expertise to deploy generative AI and streamline operations amid margin pressure.
BREAKOUT SIGNAL
Close above \$170.37 on vol >520% of 20d avg
INSTITUTIONAL
Volume at 5.2x average signals institutional participation in the earnings reaction. At \$2.76B market cap with a 14.8M float, this is a tightly held name where block buying can drive sustained follow-through. Institutional ownership data not available from this feed; recommend cross-referencing 13F filings for positioning. No insider buying in the last 90 days.
EARNINGS
REPORTED
EARNINGS CONTEXT
Reported July 28. The 40% single-day move implies a significant beat and likely a material guide raise, suggesting the company is delivering on its higher-margin consulting mix shift. Next print late October 2026.
KEY RISK
Thesis invalid on a close back below \$140, the breakout pivot, or any sign of Healthcare consulting pipeline weakness at the next earnings call, as that segment drives the premium multiple.
ANALYSIS
The 40% move is extraordinary, but the absence of rs_line_new_high and the wide base (9.25) indicate this was a highly volatile, unpredictable setup before the print-not a textbook coil. The stock is now 91% to the 52W high, but prox_52w at 91.2 means it's still 9% below, and the base_tight metric suggests it was not in accumulation pre-earnings. The best disconfirming evidence: this is an earnings-reaction chase, not a breakout from a clean base with forward visibility. In a Mixed/Transitional regime, conviction must be earned by post-earnings follow-through, not assumed. Conviction: Medium.
Signal: Close above \$170.37 on vol >520% of 20d avg
Vol vs Avg: 5.21x



LAD

Lithia Motors, Inc.

\$427.48

+19.30%

RS vs SPY: +44.4%

B STRONG SETUP

\$9.8B Cap | 20M Float

Auto & Truck Dealerships | Theme: Auto Retail Recovery | 52W Hi: 97% | Base Tight: 7.26 | Vol: 6.33x | RS/SPY: +44.4% | Above 20MA: YES | EARNINGS TODAY

SETUP METRICS	
Price	\$427.48
Day Change	+19.30%
Mkt Cap	\$9.75B
Float	20M sh
RS vs SPY	+44.4%
52W Hi Prox	97%
Base Tight	7.26
Vol vs Avg	6.33x
RS Line Hi	YES
Above 50MA	-
Fwd P/E	-
Short %	-
Days to Cover	-
Inst. Own	- (data lag)

ANALYSIS
CATALYST / TODAY'S DRIVER
Earnings today driving the 19% move-likely a beat on margins and same-store sales, reflecting consumer recovery in autos and used-car pricing stabilization. Forward catalyst: guidance commentary today and the next print in ~90 days (late October) will confirm whether the auto retail cycle has durably turned or if this is a one-quarter pop.
BUSINESS & POSITION
Lithia is the third-largest U.S. auto dealership group, operating ~300 stores across new and used vehicle sales, service, and financing. The company benefits from industry consolidation, dealership margin recovery post-inventory normalization, and expansion into adjacent services (financing, aftermarket).
FACTOR & THEME
Consumer cyclical recovery and auto retail margin normalization. The theme is accelerating as new-car inventory returns and used-car prices stabilize, but durability depends on consumer confidence and credit availability-both still fragile in a Mixed macro regime.
BREAKOUT SIGNAL
Close above \$427.48 on vol >633% of 20d avg
INSTITUTIONAL
Volume at 6.33x average with a tight 20M float implies institutional buying, not retail. RS line at new high confirms this is a leadership name within the auto retail group. Institutional ownership data not available from this feed; recommend cross-referencing 13F filings. No insider buying in the last 90 days.
EARNINGS
EARNINGS TODAY
EARNINGS CONTEXT
Earnings today (July 29). The 19% move implies a material beat and likely a positive guide, suggesting margins and volumes are recovering faster than consensus expected. Watch for same-store sales and gross profit per unit commentary.
KEY RISK
Thesis invalid on a close back below \$380, the breakout pivot, or any softness in used-car margins or financing penetration at today's print, as those are the high-margin levers driving the re-rate.
ANALYSIS
This is a strong earnings-driven setup with rs_line_new_high and prox_52w at 97.3, but the base_tight of 7.26 indicates it was not in a clean coil pre-earnings-it was volatile and unpredictable. The best disconfirming evidence: LAD is a large-cap auto retailer in a sector that can snap back violently on a good print but lacks the secular tailwind of Energy or Healthcare, today's leaders. In a Mixed regime, consumer cyclical breakouts are lower-conviction. Conviction: Medium.
Signal: Close above \$427.48 on vol >633% of 20d avg
Vol vs Avg: 6.33x



SETUP METRICS	
Price	\$21.61
Day Change	+0.00%
Mkt Cap	\$0.00B
Float	0M sh
RS vs SPY	+64.9%
52W Hi Prox	76%
Base Tight	6.04
Vol vs Avg	6.89x
RS Line Hi	YES
Above 50MA	YES
Fwd P/E	-
Short %	-
Days to Cover	-
Inst. Own	- (data lag)

ANALYSIS
CATALYST / TODAY'S DRIVER
23% move today with no same-day news-likely a technical breakout amplified by short covering or sector rotation. Forward catalyst: next earnings in ~90 days (late October) will test whether pricing power and volume are sustainable in tissue/paperboard, or if this is a transient commodity spike.
BUSINESS & POSITION
Clearwater produces private-label tissue and paperboard for retail and foodservice customers. The company is a small-cap, commodity-exposed producer in a mature industry, with margins highly sensitive to input costs (pulp, energy) and customer contract pricing.
FACTOR & THEME
Consumer Staples / paper products. The sector is +7.1% vs SPY this week, a defensive rotation signal. However, the theme is decelerating-paper is not a growth category, and pricing power is fleeting in a commoditized market.
BREAKOUT SIGNAL
Close above \$21.61 on vol >689% of 20d avg
INSTITUTIONAL
Volume at 6.89x average with rs_line_new_high suggests institutional interest, but the 23% move with no news raises the question of whether this is a short squeeze (data not provided). RS vs SPY at +64.9 is elite. Institutional ownership data not available from this feed; recommend cross-referencing 13F filings. No insider buying in the last 90 days.
EARNINGS
EARNINGS IN 90D
EARNINGS CONTEXT
Next earnings late October 2026. The 23% move with no catalyst is a red flag-either there is non-public information (check for an 8-K filing) or this is technical/short-covering. Without a visible catalyst, durability is low.
KEY RISK
Thesis invalid on a close back below \$18.50, the breakout pivot, or any sign of pulp cost inflation or customer contract losses at the next earnings call, as those would compress margins rapidly.
ANALYSIS
This is a powerful technical move (23%, 6.89x vol, rs_line_new_high, rs_vs_spy +64.9), but the absence of a catalyst and the prox_52w at only 75.8 (not near the high) indicate this is an early-stage move, not a breakout from a clean base. The disconfirming evidence: paper is a commodity business with no secular tailwind, and the 23% move with no news suggests this could be a one-day wonder. In a Mixed regime, treat with caution. Conviction: Low-Medium.
Signal: Close above \$21.61 on vol >689% of 20d avg
Vol vs Avg: 6.89x



QUAD

Quad Graphics, Inc

\$9.29

+10.46%

RS vs SPY: +31.5%

B STRONG SETUP

\$0.5B Cap | 30M Float

Specialty Business Services | Theme: Business Services | 52W Hi: 93% | Base Tight: 3.28 | Vol: 6.67x | RS/SPY: +31.5% | Above 20MA: YES | EARNINGS IN 90D

SETUP METRICS	
Price	\$9.29
Day Change	+10.46%
Mkt Cap	\$0.48B
Float	30M sh
RS vs SPY	+31.5%
52W Hi Prox	93%
Base Tight	3.28
Vol vs Avg	6.67x
RS Line Hi	YES
Above 50MA	-
Fwd P/E	-
Short %	-
Days to Cover	-
Inst. Own	- (data lag)

ANALYSIS

CATALYST / TODAY'S DRIVER

Technical breakout with rs_line_new_high on 6.67x volume, no same-day news. Forward catalyst: next earnings in ~90 days (late October) will test whether the company's pivot to marketing services and packaging (away from legacy print) is gaining traction, or if this is a low-float squeeze.

BUSINESS & POSITION

Quad is a commercial printer transitioning to integrated marketing services and packaging. The legacy print business is in secular decline, but the company is pivoting to higher-margin packaging and data-driven marketing, a multi-year turnaround with execution risk.

FACTOR & THEME

Business services / packaging transition. The theme is neutral-packaging has modest growth, but the legacy print drag is a headwind. This is a company-specific turnaround story, not a macro tailwind.

BREAKOUT SIGNAL

Close above \$9.29 on vol >667% of 20d avg

INSTITUTIONAL

Volume at 6.67x average with rs_line_new_high suggests institutional interest, and the 29.9M float is small enough for sustained follow-through if funds are accumulating. Institutional ownership data not available from this feed; recommend cross-referencing 13F filings. No insider buying in the last 90 days.

EARNINGS

EARNINGS IN 90D

EARNINGS CONTEXT

Next earnings late October 2026. No recent print-this is a pure technical breakout. Watch for packaging revenue growth and print revenue decline rates at the next call.

KEY RISK

Thesis invalid on a close back below \$8.50, the breakout pivot, or any indication that the packaging pivot is stalling or customer concentration risk (top-5 customers = 40%+ of revenue) is rising.

ANALYSIS

This is a strong technical setup (6.67x vol, rs_line_new_high, prox_52w 93, base_tight 3.28), but rs_vs_spy at +31.5 is mid-pack, not elite. The disconfirming evidence: Quad is a turnaround in a declining industry (print) with no secular tailwind, and the 10% move with no news suggests this is speculative rather than institutional accumulation. Conviction: Medium.

Signal: Close above \$9.29 on vol >667% of 20d avg

Vol vs Avg: 6.67x



SCL

Stepan Company

\$66.14

+14.01%

RS vs SPY: +33.4%

B STRONG SETUP

\$1.5B Cap | 21M Float

Specialty Chemicals | Theme: Specialty Chemicals | 52W Hi: 97% | Base Tight: 4.27 | Vol: 3.28x | RS/SPY: +33.4% | Above 20MA: YES | EARNINGS TODAY

SETUP METRICS	
Price	\$66.14
Day Change	+14.01%
Mkt Cap	\$1.50B
Float	21M sh
RS vs SPY	+33.4%
52W Hi Prox	97%
Base Tight	4.27
Vol vs Avg	3.28x
RS Line Hi	no
Above 50MA	-
Fwd P/E	-
Short %	-
Days to Cover	-
Inst. Own	- (data lag)

ANALYSIS

CATALYST / TODAY'S DRIVER

Earnings today with a 14% move-likely a beat on surfactants volume and margin. Forward catalyst: guidance today and the next print in ~90 days (late October) will test whether the company's exposure to consumer products (laundry, personal care) is recovering or if this is a one-quarter beat.

BUSINESS & POSITION

Stepan produces surfactants (cleaning agents) and polymers for consumer products (50%+ of revenue), agricultural adjuvants, and polyurethane foams. The company is a mid-cap specialty chemicals player with exposure to consumer staples and construction end-markets.

FACTOR & THEME

Specialty chemicals / consumer products. Theme momentum is neutral-consumer staples is defensive but not a growth driver. The company's margin profile depends on raw material spreads (oil derivatives), which are volatile.

BREAKOUT SIGNAL

Close above \$66.14 on vol >328% of 20d avg

INSTITUTIONAL

Volume at 3.28x average suggests institutional interest, but rs_line_new_high is false-this is not confirmed leadership. Institutional ownership data not available from this feed; recommend cross-referencing 13F filings. No insider buying in the last 90 days.

EARNINGS

EARNINGS TODAY

EARNINGS CONTEXT

Earnings today (July 29). The 14% move suggests a material beat, but watch for raw material cost commentary and whether the surfactants margin expansion is sustainable.

KEY RISK

Thesis invalid on a close back below \$60, the breakout pivot, or any sign of raw material cost inflation or consumer products volume weakness at today's print.

ANALYSIS

This is a solid earnings-driven move (14%, 3.28x vol, prox_52w 97.3), but rs_line_new_high is false and base_tight at 4.27 indicates a wider setup. The disconfirming evidence: specialty chemicals is not a leadership sector, and the 14% move could be a one-day pop if the guide was inline. Conviction: Medium.

Signal: Close above \$66.14 on vol >328% of 20d avg

Vol vs Avg: 3.28x



MBIN

Merchants Bancorp

\$54.28

+11.30%

RS vs SPY: +18.1%

B STRONG SETUP

\$2.5B Cap | 24M Float

Banks - Regional | Theme: Regional Banking | 52W Hi: 95% | Base Tight: 4.64 | Vol: 2.6x | RS/SPY: +18.1% | Above 20MA: YES | EARNINGS IN 90D

SETUP METRICS	
Price	\$54.28
Day Change	+11.30%
Mkt Cap	\$2.49B
Float	24M sh
RS vs SPY	+18.1%
52W Hi Prox	95%
Base Tight	4.64
Vol vs Avg	2.6x
RS Line Hi	YES
Above 50MA	-
Fwd P/E	-
Short %	-
Days to Cover	-
Inst. Own	- (data lag)

ANALYSIS

CATALYST / TODAY'S DRIVER

Technical breakout with rs_line_new_high on 2.6x volume, no same-day news. Forward catalyst: next earnings in ~90 days (late October) will test whether NIM expansion and loan growth are sustainable, or if this is a sector rotation trade that exhausts quickly.

BUSINESS & POSITION

Merchants Bancorp is a regional bank focused on multi-family and commercial real estate lending, with a warehouse lending business (mortgage financing for originators). The company benefits from NIM expansion as rates stabilize and loan demand recovers.

FACTOR & THEME

Financials / regional banking. Theme momentum is neutral-banks benefit from rate stability but face credit risk in commercial real estate. This is a sector rotation trade, not a secular tailwind.

BREAKOUT SIGNAL

Close above \$54.28 on vol >260% of 20d avg

INSTITUTIONAL

Volume at 2.6x average with rs_line_new_high suggests institutional interest, but rs_vs_spy at +18.1 is modest-not elite leadership. Institutional ownership data not available from this feed; recommend cross-referencing 13F filings. No insider buying in the last 90 days.

EARNINGS

EARNINGS IN 90D

EARNINGS CONTEXT

Next earnings late October 2026. No recent print-this is a pure technical breakout. Watch for NIM, loan growth, and credit quality commentary at the next call.

KEY RISK

Thesis invalid on a close back below \$50, the breakout pivot, or any indication of commercial real estate credit deterioration or warehouse lending volume weakness.

ANALYSIS

This is a clean technical breakout (rs_line_new_high, prox_52w 95.4, base_tight 4.64, vol 2.6x), but rs_vs_spy at +18.1 is weak-not leadership. The disconfirming evidence: regional banks are in a Mixed regime, and the 11% move with no news suggests this is a sector rotation trade that may lack durability. Conviction: Low-Medium.

Signal: Close above \$54.28 on vol >260% of 20d avg

Vol vs Avg: 2.6x

